

ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 1, 2026 • THE JERUSALEM POST

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Haifa fest announces varied Israeli lineup

• By HANNAH BROWN

The Haifa International Film Festival has announced its Israeli lineup for its 42nd edition, which will take place during Sukkot from September 26 through October 3.

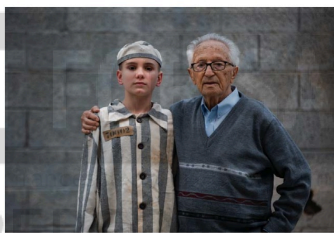
Twelve diverse movies highlight the variety of Israeli cinema, exploring war, peace, the arts, and much more. They will compete in the main Israeli film competition. There will also be premieres, documentaries on major cultural figures, special events, and a short-film competition.

This year, seven narrative features and five documentaries will compete together in the Israeli competition, an innovation introduced by the festival's artistic director, Yaron Shamir, who believes that different types of films should be presented in a single program.

Among the documentaries is a new film from one of Israel's most acclaimed and prolific documentary directors, Tomer Heymann.

The film, *I Want to Tell My Story*, is about Shimon Rothschild, who, approaching his 100th birthday, reconstructs his extraordinary life with Heymann on a specially built studio set. Rothschild directs actors portraying members of his family who were murdered in the Holocaust, as he revisits his survival of Auschwitz, medical experiments at the Sachsenhausen concentration camp, a death march, and his life after the war.

Groundbreaking Ethiopi-



'I WANT to Tell My Story' by Tomer Heymann, about Holocaust survivor Shimon Rothschild. (Dafna Talmon)

an-Israeli director Samuel Ben's narrative feature *Flager* (and) is set in Ethiopia in 1973 and tells the story of a Jewish family preparing for the dangerous journey toward Israel through Sudan.

The family patriarch, Yitzhak, initially refuses to abandon the land and farm he has built, putting him at odds with his wife, who is determined to leave with their children.

Marco Carmel's much-anticipated *Double Panther* is based on the true story of Yaakov Zada, a criminal planted as an informer inside Israel's Mizrahi Black Panther movement, who gradually begins to identify with its members and their cause.

Reut Akerman directs and stars in *Stap!* which is about an adopted woman whose biological mother dies just as she is rushing to see her.

The death brings her face-to-face with the family she has never known, including her biological father, a drug addict she has not seen since childhood, and forces her to confront conflicting identities and loyalties.

The late Nitzan Gilady's *Thin Shalt Love* centers on a young ultra-Orthodox woman whose marriage is tested when she discovers why her husband was absent from a crucial meeting with their rabbi.

Yael Elkana, Michael Moshonov, and Lena Friedland star in the film.

Gilady, who died this summer, won acclaim both for documentaries such as *In Summer Custody* and feature films, including *Wedding Doll*. Shiran Sharabany's *Spikes* follows three childhood friends from a remote northern moshav who hitchhike toward a costume party in the desert and slowly realize their



'DOUBLE PANTHER' by Marco Carmel. (Vered Adir)

youthful bond may be nearing its end.

Many Lozovsky's *Journey Dreams* is a documentary about a mother and daughter who travel together through war-torn Ukraine.

Veteran director Dina Zvi Riklis returns with *Blue Marks*, based on Emilie Moatti's best-selling novel about a man thrown into an existential crisis when a medical diagnosis forces him to give up carbohydrates.

Other competition drama films include *Farewell to Dought*, Shimon Sha's Jerusalem-set comedy-drama about a man thrown into an existential crisis when a medical diagnosis forces him to give up carbohydrates. Documentaries reflect the divisions and traumas of con-

temporary Israel.

Children of Hebron, directed by Elad Goldberg with codirector Keren Hamed Wilder, examines people who grew up amid violence in Hebron and asks how childhood in a conflict zone shaped the adults they became.

In *A Place Called Hope*, director Eitan Cohen travels through Israel with his young son during a ceasefire in search of the meaning of hope.

Uri Levi's *Peace 20 30* follows Maoz Inon, whose parents were killed on October 7, and who responds to his loss by becoming an activist for peace.

OUTSIDE THE competition, the festival will introduce several new Israeli films in premiere screenings, including Raanan Tessler's *Judoka*, about a 17-year-old athlete who abandons his sports boarding school after a family crisis; Imri Matalon's *Many Waters*, starring Lili Kornowski and

Israeli short film wins San Francisco sci-fi award

• By HANNAH BROWN

Israeli filmmaker Eyal Padian's animated short film *Two Robots* has won the Best Mini Film award at the San Francisco Science Fiction Short Film & TV Awards.

The film will be screened on September 13 at the Marina Theatre in San Francisco as part of the festival, which is produced by TasteTV and is devoted to short-form science fiction film and television.

Two Robots is the first episode of Padian's animated series *Robot Hotel*, which is set in a luxury hotel operated entirely by robots. In the episode, a veteran service robot trains a new apprentice, and a low-key rivalry gradually develops between them.

The film contains almost no dialogue, and the story is conveyed primarily through movement, rhythm, and the characters' looks and gestures. *Robot Hotel* currently consists of 10 episodes, all written, directed, and produced by Padian. He also created the video sequencing using artificial intelligence tools.

The San Francisco prize is the latest in a series of awards Padian has received at international film festivals in recent months.

In May, his short film *The Bird*, about a friendship between an elderly man and a bird, won Best Super Short Film at the Berlin Indie Shorts Festival.

Venice Film Festival grapples with activist demands over Gaza, Israel

• By HANNAH BROWN

Film festival executives used to spend their time programming movies, inviting guests, and planning events, but now they must cope with demands to politicize their festivals, specifically demands for the festivals to focus on Gaza and Israel. This has been the case more than ever in the run-up to the 83rd Venice International Film Festival, which opens on Wednesday.

Festivals generally open with a press conference in which the jurors in the main competition answer questions, but this led to controversy last year at Venice, when director Alexander Payne, who headed the jury, said he was not prepared to speak about Gaza, and this year at the Berlin International Film Festival, when jury president Wim Wenders declined to speak on the issue and said filmmakers should steer clear of politics.

Last week, the organizers of Venice announced that they were canceling the opening press conference.

Deadline reported that the festival staff denied that this was out of a desire to avoid questions about the Israel-Hamas conflict, claiming it was due to scheduling conflicts.

But on Sunday, Venice made an about-face and said that it would hold a panel featuring the jurors on Wednesday. This year, the international jury is headed by actress/director Maggie Gyllenhaal.

The other jury members are Tunisian director and screenwriter Kaouther Ben Hania (who made *The Voice of Hind Rajib*, about a Palestinian girl in Gaza killed by Israeli fire, which won the Grand Jury Prize last year), English composer and artist Daniel Blumberg, Italian prof Francesco Caselli, French director and screenwriter Xavier Giannoli, Afghan director and screenwriter Shahinoo Sadat, and the Hong Kong director and producer Johnnie To.

The jury will have its work cut out pacifying activists, especially after the letter was published last weekend by the Venice4Palestine collective,



WORKERS INSTALL signs ahead of the 83rd Venice International Film Festival, in Venice, yesterday. (Anastasia Ranzoni/Getty Images)

signed by notable figures such as anti-Israel musician Roger Waters, calling on the festival, its sponsor, the

Venice Biennale, and the rest of the industry to condemn Israel. Other signatories include Nobel author

Annie Ernaux and directors Matteo Garrone and Céline Sciamma.

Last year, the group made a similar demand and held demonstrations against Israeli policy.

"One year after its first appeal, Venice4Palestine is once again calling on the Venice Biennale, the Venice International Film Festival and professionals across the film, audiovisual and cultural sectors to take concrete action in support of Palestine," the group wrote in its latest letter.

Among the "concrete action" it calls for is "greater transparency throughout the film industry and the suspension of agreements with organisations and institutions linked to the Israeli government, the introduction of safeguards for professionals who choose to dissociate themselves from such ties."

This line is worrisome to Israeli filmmakers, virtually all of whom take some funding from film funds that receive government money. These include left-wing art house favorites such as Nadav Lapid and

Amos Gitai, whose latest film, *The Road to Jericho*, will be shown at Venice. This amounts to a veiled call to boycott all Israeli filmmakers.

The Venice4Palestine letter also called for the Palestinian flag to be flown throughout the festival to herald the inclusion of two Palestinian films in the festival: Ahmed Haseem's *Citizen Osama* and Muayad Alayan's *Conversation with the Sea*.

Yuvael Abraham and Rachel Svoz, two Israelis who co-directed the Oscar-winning *No Other Land*, have a new doc at Venice, *Azra*, about civilian deaths in Gaza during the war.

Venice4Palestine has also announced that it will hold a panel, "And Yet Gaza Continues to Burn - What Is the Point of Seeing If We Do Not Act?" as part of the Giornate degli Autori.

While it defines itself as a pro-Palestinian group, Venice4Palestine makes no mention of Hamas in its letter, although Hamas has been widely accused of executing and torturing Palestinians who oppose it.

Shoah play 'Here There Are Blueberries' to play Broadway

• By MOSHE LEON

The Pulitzer Prize-nominated documentary play *Here There Are Blueberries* is headed to Broadway this fall, bringing a chilling historical mystery to New York's primary commercial theater district.

The acclaimed drama will play a limited 10-week engagement at the Barrymore Theatre, with preview performances beginning November 2, and an official opening night scheduled for November 9.

The play chronicles the true story of how architects at the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum in Washington, DC, reacted when they received a unique and deeply unsettling donation in 2007.

Unlike traditional historical photographs that document the horrors and suffering of victims, this rare photo album captured the social lives and leisure hours of Nazi officials and staff at the Auschwitz concentration camp.

The images depict personnel smiling, laughing, and enjoying downtime, while unfathomable atrocities were being committed just outside the frame.

The Pulitzer Prize committee lauded the piece as an "elegant and devastating" work of documentary theater that tackles a complex, unresolved psychological mystery: how human beings can insist on maintaining a normal routine while participating in unimaginable evil.

Written by Moisés Kaufman and Amanda Groch of the New York-based Tectonic Theater Project - famed for *The Laramie Project* - the play is structured like a historical detective story. The audience follows museum researchers as they piece together who is in the photographs and examine what the images reveal about human nature.

Moisés Kaufman conceived the original idea and serves as director, and producer Brian and Dayna Lee are leading the commercial Broadway run.

Casting details have not yet been announced.

Before making its leap to Broadway, the play won the 2025 Lucille Lortel Award for Outstanding Play. It was heavily developed across the American non-profit theater circuit, starting as a Miami workshop in 2018 before premiering in San Diego in 2022.

It has since staged successful runs in Washington, DC, Lower Manhattan, New Jersey, California, Seattle, and at London's Theatre Royal Stratford East.

In a joint interview with *The New York Times*, the playwrights expressed that bringing the show to a commercial Broadway stage offers a rare opportunity to spark a massive cultural dialogue.

"There is something unique about Broadway, where a play opens up a national conversation," Gronich said, emphasizing that the ethical and historical questions raised by the album feel more urgent by the day.

After nearly a decade, Keren Peles releases 'One Night in April' album

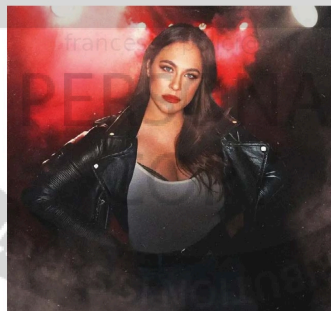
• Walla

After nearly a decade, Israeli singer-songwriter Keren Peles has released the soundtrack for her hit musical cabaret, *One Night in April* (Laila Echad B'April), as a studio album.

The release marks a major milestone for the production, which has evolved through numerous iterations over nearly a decade. The official soundtrack features contributions from a star-studded lineup of Israeli artists who have performed in or collaborated with the show over the years, including Alon Eder, Miri Mesika, Yarden Azaiz, Guri Alfi, and Keren Mor.

One Night in April originally debuted at Habima Theatre starring Peles alongside Amir Dadon, and was later performed with Angel Bonanni under the direction of Moshe Keptan.

Since its theatrical premiere, the boundary-pushing rock cabaret has broken out of tradi-



THE COVER PHOTO of the new soundtrack. (Galit Wertheim)

tional theater spaces to become a cultural staple. The production has completed three large-scale runs at Hangar 11 and has spent the last two years headlining regular, packed shows

at the Barby club in Tel Aviv, where musician Alon Eder currently performs alongside Peles.

The newly released album combines various recordings

captured over the years in Peles's home studio as well as select live concert performances.

"This cabaret is a life's journey that put me through hell," Peles shared in an official statement regarding the release. "It started being written 10 years ago and is only now seeing the light of day as a soundtrack after countless incarnations and upheavals. *One Night in April* is my most significant creation - or perhaps, I am simply a product of it."

The production's success has also reached international audiences. An English-language adaptation of the cabaret, titled *April Fools*, previously ran at the Segal Centre for Performing Arts in Montreal, also under Peles's direction.

Peles is scheduled to return to the Barby in Tel Aviv for two special celebratory performances on September 1 and September 2.

The full album is now available across major streaming platforms via D-Music.